

Anchoring Price Experiment Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 20-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	anchoring-price-experiment

Big idea: Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Anchoring Price Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can knowers fully explain their own judgements?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value.
- Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

1. Randomly give students a high-anchor or low-anchor version of the sheet.
2. Students answer whether the true value is higher or lower than the anchor.
3. Students then give their best estimate.
4. Compare average estimates across anchor groups.
5. Debrief why irrelevant numbers can influence judgement.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: What does bias reveal about human judgement?
- Can we know our own reasons for a decision?
- How do human scientists design studies to detect hidden influences?

Knowledge Questions

- Can knowers fully explain their own judgements?
- How can experiments reveal hidden influences?
- When does context become evidence and when is it bias?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with students estimate a fair price after seeing high or low anchor numbers. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...